

Anniversary of the Apology

February 13th

On February 13th 2008 Prime Minister Kevin Rudd formally apologised for past policies that had forcibly removed Aboriginal children from the families.

“We apologise for the laws and policies of successive Parliaments and governments that have inflicted profound grief, suffering and loss on these our fellow Australians. We apologise especially for the removal of Aboriginal and Torres Strait Islander children from their families, their communities and their country” Kevin Rudd, 2008



Who are the Stolen Generations?

The term “Stolen Generations” refers to Aboriginal and Torres Strait Islander Australians who were forcibly removed, as children, from their families and communities by government, welfare or church authorities and placed into institutional care or with non- Indigenous foster families. The forced removal of Aboriginal and Torres Strait Islander children began as early as the mid- 1800s and continued until 1970. Many of these removals occurred as the result of official laws and policies aimed at assimilating the Aboriginal and Torres Strait Islander population into the wider community.



How do we know their stories are true?

All State and Territory governments have acknowledged past practices and policies of forced removal of Aboriginal and Torres Strait Islander children on the basis of race. As part of this formal acknowledgement, all State and Territory governments have apologised for the trauma these policies have caused. The report of the Inquiry into the Separation of Aboriginal and Torres Strait Islander Children from their Families, the Bringing Them Home report, contains extensive evidence of past practices and policies which resulted in the removal of children.



The report also details the conditions into which many of the children were placed and discusses the devastating impact this has had on individuals, their families and the broader Aboriginal and Torres Strait Islander community. The Inquiry took evidence from Aboriginal and Torres Strait Islander people, government and church representatives, former mission staff, foster and adoptive parents, doctors and health professionals, academics, police and others. It received over 777 submissions, including 535 from Aboriginal and Torres Strait Islander individuals and organisations, 49 from church organisations and 7 from governments.

Why was it important to apologise to the Stolen Generations?

The Bringing Them Home report found that the forced removal of Aboriginal and Torres Strait Islander children from their families and communities has had life-long and profoundly disabling consequences for those taken, and has negatively affected the entire Aboriginal and Torres Strait Islander community. For many of the children, removal meant that they lost all connection to family, traditional land, culture and language and were taken to homes and institutions where they were often abused, neglected and unloved.

The reality of Australia's Stolen Generations is not a thing of the distant past. Children were being inappropriately removed from their families by Australian authorities until 1970. Many people affected by the tragedy of the Stolen Generations are still alive today and live with its effects.

Why did Australians of today apologise for something they weren't responsible for?

Individual Australians did not provide the Apology. The Apology was provided by the Australian Government in recognition of policies of past governments. Similarly, the former Australian Government apologised to Vietnam veterans for the policies of previous governments. No individual Australian was asked to take personal responsibility for actions of past governments.



What does the Apology mean to non-Indigenous Australians?

Following on from apologies already made by all State and Territory governments and the churches, an official apology to members of the Stolen Generations by the Australian Government was an important step towards building a respectful new relationship between Indigenous and non Indigenous Australians. Respectful relationships are essential if we are to solve persistent problems. In this way, the Apology lays the groundwork for us to work together more effectively towards achieving better outcomes for Aboriginal and Torres Strait Islander Australians.

It was an important starting point in healing the wounds of the past and an historic step forward for our nation that we can be proud of. The Apology was not an expression of personal responsibility or guilt by individual Australians but it does reflect our Australian values of compassion, justice and a fair go, and allows the victims of bad policy to feel that their pain and suffering has been acknowledged.



Why was the word 'sorry' important as part of the Apology?

The word “sorry” holds special meaning in Aboriginal and Torres Strait Islander cultures. In many Aboriginal communities, sorry is an adapted English word used to describe the rituals surrounding death (Sorry Business). Sorry, in these contexts, expresses empathy, sympathy and an acknowledgment of loss rather than responsibility. During the 2007 election campaign, then Opposition Leader Kevin Rudd also recognised the significance of the word sorry: “... simply saying that you’re sorry is such a powerful symbol. Powerful not because it represents some expiation of guilt. Powerful not because it represents any form of legal requirement. But powerful simply because it restores respect.”

Does the Apology mean that reconciliation has been achieved?

An apology from the Australian Government to the Stolen Generations is one important step in working together to achieve reconciliation between Aboriginal and Torres Strait Islander peoples and non-Indigenous peoples. It is important because it removes a barrier to us establishing a better relationship as Indigenous and non-Indigenous fellow Australians.

Closing the life expectancy gap involves consistent, long term action by governments and by all Australians, in health, education, housing, employment etc. as well as in building respectful relationships that generate better outcomes for us all.

